

Sea turtle

Green sea turtles live in warm ocean waters and coastal areas. They spend many years swimming in the open ocean until they are ready to breed. Turtles come to the surface to breathe, and they lay their eggs on land. Female green sea turtles usually return to the beach where they were born to nest.

See also

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The female green sea turtle returns to land.

Returning home

About two weeks after breeding, the female leaves the water, usually at night. She climbs ashore to find a suitable place to dig her nest.

The mother lays eggs the size of ping-pong balls. Each nest of eggs is called a clutch.

Sea turtles can sense the direction of the waves, which helps them find their way in the water.

Laying eggs in the sand

After laying up to 200 eggs in her nest, the mother covers them with sand and returns to the water. She does this several times. The eggs are incubated (kept warm) for several weeks.

Breaking out

The temperature of the sand around the eggs determines whether the young will be male (cooler) or female (warmer). The baby turtle uses a special tooth to break out of its shell.

Warm seas With flippers for limbs, sea turtles are perfectly adapted to ocean life. This green sea turtle is basking in the warm and shallow coastal waters of the Gulf of Mexico.



Protecting sea turtles

Sea turtles are endangered, and the survival of every baby is important. Turtle “head-start” programs give babies like this olive ridley a chance to grow up in captivity before being released back to the wild.

